

The Gentry and the Sectarian: Elite Status Preservation in Post-Imperial China

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Abstract

How do incumbent elites preserve their power and status after regime transition? Departing from a state-centered literature that focuses on how old elites retain control over state institutions and apparatuses, I argue that incumbent elites can also invest in social institutions to build a power base independent of the state. Such a strategy not only helps them preserve influence and prestige after losing formal political power, but also enables them to maintain control over local society, especially under conditions of state weakness. I apply this argument to explain the puzzling surge of sectarian movements following China's 1911 Republican Revolution. I contend that the revolution constituted a profound shock to the power and social standing of traditional elites, the gentry class. In response, these elites redirected resources into sectarian movements as organizational vehicles through which they could recover some of the status and influence stripped from them by regime change. Using a novel county-level dataset on the distribution of sectarian groups, I show that regions with a higher historical density of traditional elites during the Qing dynasty exhibited significantly greater sectarian prevalence. Further analysis shows that the positive relationship between elite density and sectarian prevalence is weaker in places where alternative informal organizational vessels, such as lineage clans, offered substitute channels for absorbing displaced elite resources.

1 Introduction

How do incumbent elites sustain their political and social dominance after profound political change, such as regime transition? The existing literature highlights two main pathways. The first focuses on the strategic design of institutions before the transition takes place. By shaping the rules of the new regime—through constitutions, electoral systems, and other foundational arrangements—outgoing elites can entrench their structural advantages and secure their long-term survival (Albertus and Menaldo, 2014; Albertus, 2019; Albertus and Menaldo, 2018).

When such formal institutional maneuvering is unavailable, elites may instead preserve their dominance by capturing the state apparatus through informal networks (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2008; Grzymala-Busse, 2002). They embed themselves in local governments (Martinez-Bravo et al., 2017; Sidel, 1999), judicial systems (Nalepa, 2010; Popova, 2012; Müller and Schneider, 1991), and bureaucratic agencies (Easter, 2000; Aspinall and Hicken, 2020). In doing so, they transform state institutions into arenas of informal resistance, limiting the ability of the new regime to carry out reforms that would undermine established elite interests.

However, both strategies face clear limitations. First, the ability of old elites to negotiate favorable institutional arrangements depends on their relative bargaining power and on the temporal dynamics of the transition's critical juncture (Albertus and Menaldo, 2018). When the old regime collapses abruptly rather than through a negotiated settlement, outgoing elites are often deprived of leverage and shut out of the institutional design process altogether (Haggard and Kaufman, 2016).

Second, internal state capture is inherently unstable and becomes increasingly difficult to sustain as the new regime consolidates. Once the nascent government gains strength, new elites often launch far-reaching reforms aimed at dismantling the informal networks of their predecessors (Stan, 2009; Nalepa, 2022). In addition, as local political competition deepens and parties unassociated with the old regime take root, the informal control of local governments by former elites tends to decay over time (Greene, 2026).

I identify a third strategy of elite persistence: the strategic investment in social institutions, especially religious organizations. Regime transition may deprive incumbent elites of formal political office, but it rarely eliminates the human, material, and symbolic capital they have already accumulated. These resources can be redirected into social institutions that exist outside the state. Religious organizations are particularly well suited to this role because they often combine dense grassroots networks with substantial moral legitimacy among local populations. By investing in and co-opting such institutions, outgoing elites can build a parallel foundation of authority that is more insulated from direct state intervention. This strategy is particularly effective where the state is weak, because social organizations in such settings often wield substantial influence over local

governance and the distribution of resources (Migdal, 1988).

I apply this framework to the growth of folk religious sectarian movements in Republican China between 1912 and 1949. Folk religious sects had deep historical roots in Chinese society (Overmyer, 1976). These groups typically espoused syncretic belief systems, millenarian doctrines, and visions of communal salvation (Overmyer, 1981). Such teachings not only offered an alternative moral framework to Confucianism, the empire's secular official ideology, but also were at times used to mobilize large-scale rebellions against the imperial state (Naquin, 1976; Zhang, 2014). As a result, both the imperial government and traditional elites regarded these movements not merely as heterodox belief systems, but as profound political and cultural threats, and subjected them to recurring cycles of repression (Ter Haar, 2021).

Although the 1911 Revolution brought an end to state-led persecution, the emerging national discourse posed new challenges to sectarian movements. Political elites, deeply influenced by Western intellectual currents, promoted secular nationalism and projects of modern nation-building that increasingly cast traditional religious sects as “backward superstitions” and sought to curtail their influence (Nodostup, 2010; Duara, 1996; Goossaert and Palmer, 2011). Consequently, many contemporary observers expected these heterodox folk religious organizations to fade into obsolescence.

However, rather than declining under the pressures of modernization, these sectarian groups experienced remarkable expansion during the Republican era. Folk religious sects such as Yiguan-dao and Tongshanshe rapidly developed into pervasive social institutions and built sophisticated nationwide networks (Jiao, 2020). By the late 1940s, they had reportedly attracted as many as 18 million followers (Palmer, 2011), or roughly 7 percent of China's adult population. At this scale, they constituted the most significant organized force within the religious field and represented one of the largest religious revivals in modern Chinese history.¹ Moreover, these sects became deeply embedded in local society and governance by providing essential public goods, including

¹Although a larger share of the population may have identified as Buddhist, such identification was often diffuse rather than organizational. Moreover, many self-identified Buddhists were functionally affiliated with sectarian groups (Overmyer, 1976).

charitable assistance, famine relief, and education (DuBois, 2011; Ownby, 2016; Sun, 2013). The extensive networks they constructed, together with the social functions they performed, enabled sectarian organizations to form a vast parallel institutional structure operating beyond the formal state apparatus.

I argue that the rise of sectarian organizations in Republican China reflected a strategic effort by traditional gentry elites to preserve their social status and influence after the 1911 Revolution. Under the Republican regime, the traditional gentry—whose credentials and authority had been closely tied to the imperial examination system—lost both their institutional access to political power and much of their established social standing. This rupture produced a class of displaced elites who still possessed substantial resources and local prestige but no longer enjoyed a formal channel for political incorporation. To adapt to this new environment, these elites strategically redirected their resources into sectarian movements. They used these organizations as alternative platforms for status preservation and moral authority in the absence of access to political positions. This strategy not only contributed to the growth of sectarian movements, but also transformed their political character, shifting them from historically rebellious forces into conservative institutional vessels for upholding the traditional moral order and sustaining local dominance.

Empirically, this article draws on a unique dataset constructed from local records on sectarian movements collected by the Chinese Communist Party in the early 1950s. Following the 1949 Revolution, the CCP launched a massive nationwide campaign to suppress these groups. In the course of this systematic eradication effort, approximately 18 million sectarian adherents were compelled to publicly renounce their affiliations, while nearly 860,000 sectarian leaders were detained, imprisoned, or executed. This sweeping campaign of repression generated unusually granular local documentation, creating a rare opportunity for the systematic quantitative study of these organizations.

Using historical records that document the scale of sectarian activity across more than 1,000 counties, I challenge the conventional view that sectarian movements were merely “weapons of the weak.” I show that sectarian organizations attracted more followers and recruited more leaders

in regions with higher densities of traditional elites. This relationship is not simply driven by the persistence of earlier sectarian traditions, as the results remain robust even after controlling for proximity to historical centers of sectarian activity.

Furthermore, I find that the positive relationship between historical elite density and sectarian prevalence was conditioned by the presence of alternative organizational vessels. Specifically, the effect of elite density on sectarianism was significantly weaker in areas with strong alternative informal institutions. Where robust lineage clans existed, they served as substitute institutional vessels that absorbed displaced elite capital, thereby crowding out the growth of heterodox sectarian movements.

This paper makes two main contributions. First, it advances the literature on incumbent elite persistence after regime change by identifying a society-centered pathway of elite adaptation. Existing work has emphasized how old elites survive through institutional lock-in or state capture (Albertus and Menaldo, 2018; Albertus, 2019; Albertus and Menaldo, 2014; Grzymala-Busse, 2002; Martinez-Bravo et al., 2017; Sidel, 1999; Popova, 2012). I show instead that displaced elites can preserve power by redirecting resources into religious institutions outside the state, which proved to be less vulnerable to political instability, and successfully help elites sustain prestige, influence, and local dominance even after formal political authority has been lost.

Second, by studying a religious revival after a regime shift, this article contributes to the study of religious revival under conditions of profound social disruption, including economic downturns (Costa et al., 2019), violent conflict (Zussman, 2014), and natural disasters (Sinding Bentzen, 2019). Existing scholarship has focused primarily on the demand side of this phenomenon, emphasizing how structural shocks generate psychological or material needs for religious coping among the broader population. By contrast, this paper develops an elite-centered supply-side theory of religious expansion. I argue that profound political disruption creates strong incentives for elites to reinvest their organizational capital and material resources into religious organizations, therefore driving religious revival.

The remainder of the article proceeds as follows. The first section develops the theoretical

framework, explaining how old elites invest in religious institutions to preserve their status after regime transition. The second section provides historical background on the transformation and proliferation of sectarian groups during China's Republican era. The third section introduces the data, and the fourth presents the main quantitative results. The final section concludes by discussing the broader implications of the argument.

2 Strategic Investment and Elite Survival after Political Transitions

Profound political transformations—such as regime change, foreign occupation, and post-conflict institutional overhauls such as Reconstruction following the American Civil War—fundamentally disrupt established political orders. At such critical junctures, incumbent elites tied to the preceding regime often confront existential threats to their political authority, social standing, and material interests. A central challenge for these outgoing elites is to determine how to preserve their influence and status within the new political order.

Current scholarship identifies two primary strategies. The first is institutional lock-in during negotiated transitions, through which outgoing elites shape the institutional framework of the new regime and ensure that their preferences remain formally represented. For example, they may draft constitutions that establish countermajoritarian arrangements, such as bicameral legislatures, strong constitutional courts, unelected upper chambers, and electoral rules that overrepresent minority parties (Albertus and Menaldo, 2018, 2014). Outgoing elites, especially military officers, may also retain institutional control over key political domains such as national security, military appointments, and defense budgets (Hunter, 1997, 1998). Alternatively, they may delegate governmental authority to independent state agencies—such as central banks or autonomous regulatory bodies—to insulate important policy areas from the reach of the new regime (Boylan, 2001).

The second strategy is the capture of state agencies, whereby outgoing elites maintain *de facto* control over political order and policy implementation without relying on formal institutional pro-

tections. In such cases, they exploit preexisting patronage networks, clientelistic ties, and shared illicit rents to systematically co-opt bureaucracies and local governments (Martinez-Bravo et al., 2017; Giraudy, 2015; Sidel, 1999; Nalepa, 2010; Popova, 2012). As a result, old elites' influence can outlast political transition, muting the reformist impulses of the new regime (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2008; Grzymala-Busse, 2002; Müller and Schneider, 1991; Easter, 2000; Aspinall and Hicken, 2020). These entrenched networks lead state agents to privilege old elite interests and resist policy directives issued by the new leadership. By embedding themselves within the administrative apparatus, outgoing elites build a shadow infrastructure that subverts formal oversight and blocks reforms that might undermine their position.

However, both approaches have important limitations. First, incumbent elites are not always in a position to negotiate the terms of the post-transition order. This vulnerability is especially acute when regime change occurs abruptly, stripping incumbent elites of power before they have an opportunity to bargain. Even when some negotiation is possible, old elites may be too weak during the transition to shape the institutional rules of the new regime in their favor (Albertus and Menaldo, 2018; Haggard and Kaufman, 2016). Moreover, in weakly institutionalized settings, foundational political arrangements such as constitutions are often subject to repeated revision (Levitsky and Murillo, 2009; Brinks et al., 2019). As a result, the formal protections established by departing elites may remain highly vulnerable to subsequent political contestation.

Second, internal state capture is vulnerable to the consolidation of the new regime. As the nascent government stabilizes, new political elites often pursue aggressive reforms aimed at dismantling the informal networks inherited from their predecessors (Stan, 2009; Nalepa, 2022). In addition, as local political competition intensifies and parties unconnected to the previous regime become entrenched, the informal capture of local governments tends to erode over time (Greene, 2026). State capture therefore often functions as a temporary tactic rather than a durable long-term strategy.

This paper proposes a third strategy through which incumbent elites preserve their power and status after political transition: investing in social institutions, especially religious organizations.

Whereas institutional lock-in and state capture operate through the state apparatus, this alternative strategy focuses on building power bases within society. Even when regime change strips old elites of formal office, it rarely destroys the resources they have accumulated over time. Former elites often continue to possess wealth, local prestige, organizational experience, and dense interpersonal networks. These resources can be redirected into social institutions that allow them to retain influence outside the formal political system.

Investing in social institutions brings several benefits to the elites. They provide leadership positions, mechanisms of local coordination, and socially recognized roles through which displaced elites can continue to wield authority. In this way, former elites can translate residual economic, social, and symbolic capital into a new basis of influence after losing privileged access to the state. This strategy is especially effective where state capacity is weak, as social organizations in such contexts often shape local governance by resolving disputes, organizing community defense, and providing basic public goods. Moreover, because these organizations are embedded in society rather than the state apparatus, they are often less vulnerable to the direct purges, personnel turnover, and institutional restructuring led by elites of the new regime.

Among the available social institutions, religious organizations are especially well-suited to this role. First, they often possess dense grassroots networks that old elites can enter more easily than they could build comparable organizations from scratch. By investing in preexisting religious networks, displaced elites gain access to local communities, followers, and organizational infrastructures that would otherwise be difficult to assemble. Second, religious organizations often uphold moral worldviews and social hierarchies that are more compatible with the preferences of old elites than the reformist ideologies promoted by new regimes. Third, religious institutions typically command a degree of moral legitimacy that few secular organizations can match. Leadership within such institutions therefore offers not only organizational resources, but also symbolic authority. By embedding themselves in religious organizations, former elites obtain religious prestige and moral legitimacy, which become the foundation of a durable form of social and political influence.

3 Empirical Background

3.1 Heterodox Religious Sects in Imperial China

Unlike the Islamic and Christian worlds, imperial China did not structure political authority around a single established church. Instead, the imperial state governed the ideological sphere through Confucianism, a secular tradition concerned primarily with social ethics and worldly order rather than transcendental salvation. As the official ideology of the empire, Confucianism supplied an overarching moral framework that specified the duties of the emperor, officials, and subjects, and in doing so provided a comprehensive foundation of legitimacy for the hierarchical social and political order (Zhang, 2017; Peng, 2025; Levenson, 1968).

As a secular moral framework, Confucianism did not exclude religious activities; rather, it defined the boundaries of orthodox practice by incorporating them into a Confucian moral cosmos (Yang, 1961). The state, for instance, endorsed ancestral worship insofar as it embodied *xiao* (filial piety), the virtue that served as the moral foundation of both familial and political hierarchy. At the same time, the imperial state employed a sophisticated strategy of symbolic incorporation by conferring official titles and moral attributes upon local deities, thereby integrating local cults into the empire's formal administrative and ethical order (Feuchtwang, 2003).

Yet beneath the surface of Confucian hegemony and officially sanctioned religious practice, a wide array of folk religious sects shaped the spiritual lives of many Chinese subjects. These groups were often designated by the imperial state as heterodox (*xie*). Their origins can be traced to the millenarian Daoist movements of the late Han dynasty, most notably the Way of Great Peace (Taiping Dao) and the Five Pecks of Rice movement (Wudoumi Dao) (Shek, 2004a). The character of sectarian heterodoxy changed significantly with the arrival of Buddhism, especially through the introduction of Maitreyan eschatology. Belief in Maitreya—the Future Buddha who would descend to inaugurate a new age—provided a powerful theological framework for movements that imagined a world beyond the existing social and political order (Overmyer, 1976; Shek, 2004b).

This religious synthesis reached a particularly influential form in the White Lotus tradition dur-

ing the late Yuan period. By this time, sectarian theology increasingly centered on the myth of the Eternal Mother (Wusheng Laomu), a primordial creator deity who sought to save her lost children from a world descending into catastrophe. The faith promised eventual return to a cosmic home through the salvific sequence of the Three Eras.¹ Within this eschatological vision, the Eternal Mother presided over the final era, in which the righteous would be gathered into her presence while the wicked would face destruction (Overmyer, 1976; Naquin, 1976). This shared spiritual core supported a highly decentralized organizational world composed of autonomous lineages, often designated as *dao* (ways) or *men* (gates), each with its own hereditary succession and sectarian network.

Folk religious sects presented an ontological challenge to the imperial order, as their competing moral framework—centered on transcendental redemption and radical egalitarianism—directly contested the hegemony of Confucianism (Naquin, 1976; Ter Haar, 2021). The ideological confrontation escalated further through the sects' millenarian worldview, which often functioned as a potent mechanism for mass mobilization. Believers were often encouraged to take militant action to hasten the arrival of the promised era, transforming religious fervor into open insurrection against the "demonic" state. Consequently, sectarian influence served as the catalyst for many large-scale rebellions against the imperial government, and many of them hastened or led to the collapse of the imperial government.

As a result of their ideological differences from Confucian orthodoxy and their potential for mass mobilization, religious sects in imperial China were frequent targets of state repression. Throughout successive dynasties, the imperial government perceived these autonomous religious groups as threats to social harmony and political stability (Ter Haar, 2021). This hostility was formalized during the Yuan dynasty, when the prohibition of heretical ways (*zuodao*), was first codified. The Ming dynasty established this persecution by incorporating strict statutes against heterodox teachings (*xiejiao*) into the Great Ming Code to consolidate dynastic rule. This pattern

¹The term "White Lotus" does not refer to a single, unified organization, despite the way it was often used by the imperial state for administrative convenience. Rather, it serves as a broad label for a family of sectarian traditions sharing core beliefs in the Three Eras of end-time calamity (*Sanqi Mojie*) and the Eternal Mother. For a detailed discussion of how the White Lotus label was constructed, see Ter Haar (2021).

Table 1: Major Rebellions in China Influenced by Heterodox Sects

Event	Leaders	Dynasty	Time	Sect Category
Yellow Turban Rebellion	Zhang Jiao	Han	184–205	Daoist
Sun En Lu Xun Rebellion	Sun En, Luxun	Jin	399-411	Daoist
Faqing Rebellion	Faqing	Northern Wei	515	Maitreyan
Song Zixian Rebellion	Song Zixian	Sui	613	Maitreyan
Xiang Haiming Rebellion	Xiang Haiming	Sui	613-614	Maitreyan
Wang Huaigu Rebellion	Wang Huaigu	Tang	713	Maitreyan
Wang Ze Rebellion	Wang Ze	Song	1047–1048	Maitreyan
Fang La Rebellion	Fang La	Song	1120–1121	Manichaeen
Du Keyong Rebellion	Du Keyong	Yuan	1280	White Lotus
Red Turban Rebellion	Han Shantong, Peng Yingyu	Yuan	1351–1368	Maitreyan
Tang Saier Rebellion	Tang Saier	Ming	1420	White Lotus
Wenxiang Sect Rebellion	Xu Hongru	Ming	1622	White Lotus
Wang Lun Rebellion	Wang Lun	Qing	1774	White Lotus
White Lotus Rebellion	Wang Cong'er, Yao Zhifu	Qing	1796–1804	White Lotus
Tianli Sect Rebellion	Lin Qing, Li Wencheng	Qing	1813	White Lotus
Taiping Rebellion	Hong Xiuquan, Yang Xiuqing	Qing	1851–1864	Christian-inspired

Note: In the context of Chinese history, "White Lotus" functioned primarily as an umbrella label employed by the state to categorize various heterodox movements rather than a collective identity adopted by the groups themselves (Ter Haar, 2021). This paper uses the term as a general classification because these sects shared significant theological and genealogical commonality.

of state violence intensified during the Qing dynasty, when the law was extended to criminalize not only rebellion but even the suspicion of sectarian membership.

Religious sects' ideological conflict with Confucian orthodoxy, together with the state's designation of these groups as heterodox and its repression of them, made them particularly attractive to followers from marginalized populations living outside the formal social hierarchy, including displaced peasants, itinerant workers, and small merchants (Liu and Shek, 2004; Naquin, 1976). By contrast, cultural elites rarely joined these sects, since they remained committed to the official Confucian order that underpinned their social status.

3.2 Old Wine in New Bottles? From Heterodox Sects to Redemptive Societies

The 1911 Revolution was a watershed moment for the development of religious sects. Rather than declining with modernization, folk religious sects flourished throughout the Republican era (1912–1949). Moving beyond their previously decentralized and clandestine operations, these groups began to expand their organizational reach openly. Sects such as the Moral Studies Society (Daode xueshe), the School of the Dao (Daoyuan), the Fellowship of Goodness (Tongshanshe), and Yiguandao rapidly transformed into ubiquitous social institutions with sophisticated national networks (Ownby, 2016). By the late 1940s, these organizations had recruited an estimated 18 million followers—roughly 7% of China's adult population (Palmer, 2011). This scale made them the most significant organized force in the religious field, representing one of the most substantial religious revivals in Chinese history. For comparison, during the same period, Catholicism had only 3 million followers, while Protestantism drew fewer than 1 million (Yang, 2011).

How did marginalized religious sects suddenly emerge as a major force in the Chinese religious landscape during the Republican era? The most critical factor lies in the strategic investment by traditional elites, the gentry class, as a response to their declining influence after the 1911 Revolution.

The term gentry refers to the elite class of individuals who obtained academic degrees through

the imperial examination system. This class constituted the backbone of imperial governance, as an examination degree was a strict prerequisite for entering the bureaucracy, granting the gentry a virtual monopoly on formal government positions (Ho, 1962; Peng, 2025). Furthermore, at the grassroots level, where the imperial state lacked a direct administrative presence, the gentry exercised extensive informal power. Their academic degrees provided the cultural prestige necessary to lead local society, allowing them to manage essential functions such as education, charity, and dispute resolution (Chu, 1973; Xiao, 1967; Leung, 1997; Elman, 2000; Rawski, 1979).

The 1911 Revolution and the subsequent modernization process fundamentally challenged the influence and prestige of the gentry (Fei, 1946). The formal bureaucracy was increasingly occupied by a new generation of technocrats and military officers trained in modern educational institutions, severing the gentry's traditional pathway to power (Bai and Jia, 2016). The expansion of the state's reach into local domains encroached upon the informal governance space that the gentry had previously monopolized (Duara, 1996). Culturally, as the new regime derived its legitimacy from modernization and progress, the traditional Confucian knowledge system was increasingly marginalized and was redefined as an obsolete obstacle to the development of a modern state (Esherick and Rankin, 2018).

The gentry class responded to this crisis with diverse survival strategies. One segment of the elite adapted to the new order by pursuing modern education and investing in the industrial economy, effectively transforming into urban reformists (Esherick and Rankin, 2018; Bergère, 1989; Schoppa, 1982). Others, however, sought alternative institutional vessels to preserve their social prestige and conserve the political values and moral frameworks of the traditional era.

Sectarian movements emerged as a viable option. The long historical tradition of sectarianism had left behind both an existing organizational infrastructure and deep cultural resonance among the broader population. Yet a fundamental tension remained: the gentry were rooted in Confucian orthodoxy, whereas these sects carried a long-standing reputation for heterodoxy and rebellion. I argue that this tension was resolved through a process of transformation in which gentry elites reshaped both the organizational structure and ideological profile of sectarian movements, turning

them into what the scholarly literature calls “redemptive societies” (Palmer, 2011).

Taking advantage of the looser restrictions on religious organizations under the Republic, elites helped convert these groups from loose and clandestine networks into open and more highly structured organizations. This process of institutionalization introduced clearer internal hierarchies and more bureaucratic forms of management, allowing redemptive societies to expand rapidly without succumbing as easily to the recurrent fragmentation that had characterized sectarian movements under imperial rule. At the same time, while preserving core beliefs that sustained their popular appeal, leaders of these organizations increasingly incorporated Confucian ideas into their moral teachings. By promoting traditional virtues such as filial piety, loyalty, and charity, religious sects became a conservative ideological counterweight to the progressive and modernizing discourses of the Republican era.¹

The gentry’s contributions to the expansion of religious sects helped their expansion in several ways. First, the gentry served as structural bridges between these sectarian organizations and the broader community by leveraging kinship ties, scholarly networks, and merchant associations to embed these groups within the existing social fabric. By occupying key leadership positions, gentry elites conferred institutional legitimacy and administrative expertise on these movements, which enabled them to expand recruitment and establish durable local networks (Wang, 2011; Jiao, 2020). In addition, the gentry also provided the financial support essential for sustaining infrastructural development. This funding facilitated the acquisition of physical venues and the organization of communal activities. More importantly, these resources supported essential social functions such as disaster relief and public education. These activities demonstrated the tangible social value of

¹This transformation is clearly illustrated by the trajectory of Tongshanshe, one of the largest redemptive societies of the Republican period. Tongshanshe was founded by Peng Tairong (1868–1950), a member of the lower gentry (*xiucai*) who had not held formal office before 1911. A former follower of the Way of Former Heaven (*Xiantiandao*), Peng retained core sectarian beliefs, including devotion to the Eternal Mother (*Wusheng Laomu*) and the doctrine of the Three Eras of calamity (*Sanqi Mojie*) (Jiao, 2020; Wang, 2011). At the same time, he strategically infused these teachings with Confucian elements in order to appeal to traditional intellectuals, which helped him gain the support of the gentry in his native Sichuan. Building on this early success, Peng moved to Beijing and secured endorsements from prominent former Qing aristocrats and intellectual elites. This recognition facilitated Tongshanshe’s national expansion; by 1927, the organization reportedly claimed three million members. Despite its increasingly diverse membership, the leadership and earliest followers of local branches continued to be drawn disproportionately from the gentry class (Jiao, 2020).

the organizations and lowered the barriers to recruitment by presenting the groups as benevolent public actors.¹

At the same time, the gentry elite derived substantial benefits from their investment in religious sects. First, religious sects offered a vital channel for preserving and reinventing elite prestige, which had become increasingly endangered under the new political order of the Republic. As traditional markers of status eroded, the gentry successfully converted their waning Confucian scholarly capital into a new form of religious authority. Furthermore, leadership within these organizations enabled the gentry to consolidate their dominance over grassroots society. By leveraging the religious status and mobilizational power of these sects, elites could not only prevail in protracted local disputes against competitors but also shield their communities from excessive state extraction (Duara, 1991; DuBois, 2005; Jiao, 2020).

Finally, the horizontal networks established through sectarian affiliation provided a crucial platform for elite coordination. Shared religious identities and participation in common rituals allowed competing elites to build interpersonal trust, which facilitated the expansion of their localized networks, which translated into practical economic advantages, such as providing a reliable basis for credit and fostering collaborative business ventures (DuBois, 2005; Jiao, 2020).

However, the success and institutionalization of religious sects ultimately sowed the seeds of their demise. While these organizations were largely tolerated by various administrations during the Republican era, their deep affiliation with traditional elites, massive membership bases, and dense organizational networks rendered them a formidable threat to the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) upon its ascension to power in 1949. Following the revolution, the new regime launched a comprehensive nationwide crackdown on all religious sects as part of the Campaign to Suppress Counter-revolutionaries (Zhenfan). During this period, these groups were officially categorized as "reactionary sects and secret societies" (*fandong huidaomen*) (Hung, 2010). According to official statistics, approximately 14 million lay members were forced to disaffiliate, while 800,000 leaders

¹A prominent example is the Daoyuan, a religious sect founded in 1916 that sponsored the Red Swastika Society (*Hong Wanzi Hui*), one of the largest charitable organizations in Republican China. Similarly, the Universal Moral Society (*Wanguo Daodehui*) devoted substantial effort to establishing schools for the poor. For further discussion of the Daoyuan, see Duara (2004).

were detained, sentenced, or executed. This campaign effectively dismantled the movements' organizational foundations, marking one of the most extensive instances of religious repression in modern history.¹ The thoroughness of this nationwide crackdown also produced a vast archive of documents and data, which provides rich empirical material for the research introduced in the next section.

Based on the historical context and the theoretical framework, my primary hypothesis is: The concentration of gentry elites during the Qing Dynasty is positively associated with the subsequent growth of sectarian organizations in the Republican period.

4 Data Collection

General Rule for Data Collection

To empirically investigate the proliferation of religious sects, I utilize multiple data sources across different historical periods. Because these sources reflect the administrative boundaries present at the time of their recording, I harmonize these historical units with modern county-level divisions by tracking administrative adjustments documented in local gazetteers.

Data on Religious Sects

The most systematic empirical evidence regarding the geographic distribution and organizational scale of sectarian movements is found in the extensive administrative archives generated during the state-led repression of these groups following the founding of the People's Republic of China. This repression followed a standardized national protocol, resulting in a rigorous corpus of documentation within the internal Public Security Archives (Gong'an dang'an) compiled during the Campaign to Suppress Counter-revolutionaries (Zhenfan). These archival records were subsequently summarized and incorporated into local gazetteers (difangzhi), which serve as the official

¹Although folk sectarian movements periodically resurfaced in later decades, they lacked a nationalized organizational network. These later manifestations bore a closer resemblance to the localized, heterodox movements of imperial China. Rather than operating openly, they functioned clandestinely on a small scale, typically centered around a single charismatic leader and devoid of cross-regional coordination.

historical records for each administrative division. Because the campaign involved a comprehensive census of sectarian membership and leadership, these records provide a granular map of the social foundations of religious sects that is otherwise unavailable in traditional historical sources. In Appendix B, I provide a figure of the example gazetteer section on religious sects.

A significant portion of these records has been centralized in *A Compendium of Historical Materials on Chinese Sects and Secret Societies* (Zhao, 2004). To supplement this collection, I identified additional gazetteers containing relevant sectarian sections that were omitted from the 2004 compendium. Through systematic text reading and manual entry, I constructed a county-level dataset encompassing approximately 1,000 counties, representing roughly 60 percent of the Chinese population in the early 1950s. My data collection captures information on leadership figures (daoshou), ordinary adherents (daotu), and ritual venues (tantang). For a small subset (5%) of counties where gazetteers recorded the number of leaders and venues but omitted the count of adherents, I employed imputation techniques to estimate the size of the lay membership based on these available organizational indicators.

I additionally collected data on the number of sectarian leaders, whose records are more scarce. I successfully obtained consistent data for 690 counties, providing a secondary metric to validate the primary membership statistics.

Gentry Size

In late imperial China, gentry status was formally institutionalized through the attainment of academic degrees via the civil service examinations (Chang, 2011). Consequently, the geographic distribution and density of examination degree holders provide a reliable proxy for the strength and size of the gentry class across different regions.

I derived the spatial distribution of the gentry using data from *Index to the Stele Records of Ming and Qing Dynasty Jinshi Names* (Zhu and Xie, 1980), which provides a comprehensive record of the hometown for over 20,000 Jinshi in Qing Dynasty, the holders of the highest degree during the Qing dynasty. While the gentry class was numerically dominated by lower-degree holders (shengyuan and juren), systematic data for these sub-groups are significantly more difficult to

obtain at a granular level. Nevertheless, the number of Jinshi serves as a robust proxy for the overall gentry class, as the production of Jinshi was not an isolated academic achievement but rather the apex of a localized educational and economic infrastructure; counties capable of producing high-level degree holders typically possessed a proportionally larger base of lower-tier literati and wealthy lineages.

Population

I draw population data primarily from Wu et al. (2022), who compiled six waves of the Chinese census (1953, 1964, 1982, 1990, 2000, and 2010) and mapped them onto the historical administrative jurisdictions used in my sectarian dataset. I successfully matched most counties using the Wu et al. (2022) dataset; for the remaining cases, I extracted data from specific county gazetteers. I employ the 1953 census as a proxy for the pre-revolution population.

Control Variable: Distance to Historical Sectarian Centers

Sectarian movements were deeply rooted in Chinese history. Consequently, the observed scale of sectarian organizations during the Republican era might simply reflect the geographical persistence of long-standing traditions rather than a strategic response by the gentry to the political shocks of the 1911 Revolution. If sectarianism is merely a continuation of historical activities, the correlation between gentry density and Republican-era sects could be spurious.¹

To control for historical sectarian activities, I introduced a control variable representing the natural logarithm of the minimum great-circle distance from each county to three foundational centers of sectarian movements: Luanzhou, Huaxian, and Hangzhou. Luanzhou was the ancestral seat of the Eight Trigrams (Bagua Jiao) and the source of sectarian symbolic orthodoxy in North China (Naquin, 1976). Huaxian served as the center of the 1813 Eight Trigrams uprising, representing the peak of historical militant mobilization (Naquin, 1976). Hangzhou is the point of origin for the

¹Such a bias is likely to be an attenuation bias rather than an overestimation of the main effect. Traditional sectarianism in the Qing dynasty flourished primarily in ecologically fragile or peripheral areas where the gentry class was historically sparse and state capacity was weak, rather than regions that produced large numbers of cultural elites (Perry, 1980; Naquin, 1976). If these historical traditions persisted into the Republican era, their concentration in low-gentry regions would create a baseline negative correlation between gentry density and sectarian presence.

Luo Sect (Luo Jiao), which provided the organizational and theological foundations for numerous subsequent movements (Shek and Noguchi, 2004).

5 Empirical Results

Main Results

My primary hypothesis predicts that the historical size of the gentry class is positively correlated with the scale of subsequent sectarian movements. Since systematic data on sectarian membership are unavailable for the Qing period, the empirical analysis relies on a cross-sectional strategy utilizing records from the 1950s. Table 2 illustrates the relationship between historical gentry density and the concentration of sectarian members recorded during the suppression campaigns of the early 1950s. To ensure consistency across administrative units, both the independent variable (historical gentry density) and the dependent variable (sectarian concentration) are standardized as the number of individuals per 100,000 inhabitants.

Table 2: Gentry Density and Sectarian Members

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
DV:	Sectarian Member Density					
Jinshi per capita	75.984*** (21.572)	56.197*** (18.498)	44.522** (22.464)	65.524*** (22.651)	57.881*** (18.579)	44.562* (22.848)
Dist. to Sect Center (Log)				-1.486*** (0.395)	0.604 (1.547)	-5.651 (4.618)
Observations	1074	1074	1009	1069	1069	1004
R^2	0.023	0.210	0.417	0.045	0.214	0.429
Province FE		X			X	
Prefecture FE			X			X

Notes: *p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01. Standard errors clustered at the prefecture level.

The analysis of sectarian concentration presented in Table 2 provides empirical support for the hypothesis. Column 1 reports the results of a simple bivariate regression to establish the baseline correlation between gentry density and the number of sectarian members. In columns 2 and 3,

the model incorporates increasingly stringent controls to account for unobserved heterogeneity. Specifically, Column 2 introduces province-level fixed effects to account for regional variations in governance and culture, while Column 3 applies more restrictive prefecture-level fixed effects to isolate the relationship within smaller administrative units. Columns 4 through 6 extend these specifications by incorporating a spatial control for the distance to historical sectarian centers.

The coefficient for Jinshi per capita remains positive and statistically significant across all specifications, indicating that gentry density is a robust predictor of sectarian membership. Interestingly, the distance to Qing-era centers shows no stable positive correlation. This divergence further suggests that the expansion of these societies did not merely emerge through geographical diffusion from historical strongholds. Rather, the concentration of sectarian members in the early twentieth century was driven by the availability of local gentry investment.

Table 3 confirms these patterns using sectarian leader density as an alternative dependent variable. Although the sample size is smaller due to less frequent reporting of leadership figures in county gazetteers, across all six specifications, the gentry variable remains a consistent predictor of leadership density, while the distance to Qing-era centers shows no stable positive correlation.

Table 3: Gentry Density and Sectarian Leaders

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
DV:	Sectarian Leader Density					
Jinshi per capita	4.368*** (1.379)	4.397*** (1.498)	3.637** (1.524)	4.124*** (1.350)	4.463*** (1.499)	3.584** (1.531)
Dist. to Sect Center (Log)				-17.591 (11.452)	6.276 (42.113)	-77.910 (79.990)
Observations	694	693	616	691	690	611
R^2	0.022	0.103	0.432	0.024	0.104	0.433
Province FE		X			X	
Prefecture FE			X			X

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the prefecture level.

I perform two robustness tests to validate the primary findings, with the full results shown in

Appendix C. First, I exclude counties located in ethnic minority regions that were largely excluded from the imperial examination system. In these regions, the pathways to elite status and social organization followed different logics compared to the rest of the country, and the size of traditional elites would not be captured by our Jinshi proxy.

Second, I test the robustness of the results to different functional forms of the dependent variable. In the primary analysis, I utilize the absolute number of sectarian adherents and leaders per 100,000 inhabitants, and the distribution of both are right-skewed. Although a logarithmic transformation is a standard remedy for right-skewness, it can disproportionately amplify minor variations at the lower end of the distribution. For example, a shift from one to ten members is more likely to be a product of measurement noise in historical records than a substantive organizational change, yet a log-linear model treats such fluctuations as highly significant. Nevertheless, to verify that the results are not contingent on its original scaling, I replicate the analysis using a log plus one transformation for both the density of leaders and adherents. The results still largely hold in the two robustness checks.

The Logic of Institutional Substitution

The results in the previous section establish a robust link between gentry density and sectarian activities. However, the expansion of sects during the Republican era did not occur in an institutional vacuum. I argue that the relationship between gentry density and sectarian mobilization is governed by a logic of institutional substitution. While religious sects provided a new organizational vessel for elites to preserve their influence, the gentry could also invest in existing institutions. Relying on established structures allowed them to conserve the resources required to build new organizational networks from scratch.

Lineage clans served as precisely this type of institution. Since the Ming dynasty, they had functioned as the predominant social organizations structuring local life in many parts of China (Kung and Wu, 2025). Clans participated heavily in local governance by organizing education, dispensing charity, and maintaining social safety networks. Crucially, these roles directly overlapped with the social functions that religious sects attempted to fulfill (Watson, 1982; Elman,

2000; Fei and Liu, 1982).

Furthermore, the historical alignment between the gentry and clans was significantly closer than their relationship with religious sects. While the state frequently suppressed religious sects as heterodox threats to the official imperial ideology, clans firmly situated themselves within the orthodox Confucian moral framework (Faure, 2007). Gentry and clan leadership also heavily overlapped. Financial and organizational support from the clan was often indispensable for individuals seeking to achieve academic degrees. In return, these degree holders utilized their acquired political status to further expand the influence and resources of their clans, creating a mutually reinforcing relationship (Elman, 2000; Ho, 1962).

Historical evidence shows that, following the 1911 Revolution, the Chinese gentry deepened their investment in lineage organizations as a strategic response to the erosion of their traditional prestige and political influence. They expanded communal property holdings and strengthened control over clan lands and endowments to secure a stable economic base less vulnerable to predatory state taxation. They also used lineage institutions to reinforce social discipline through genealogies, clan rules, and ancestral halls (Esherick and Rankin, 2018). In an era of warlordism and banditry, clans further served as instruments of local defense, as gentry invested in weapons and fortifications that militarized clan organizations (Watson, 1985). At the same time, elites funded important public goods through clans, including modern schools and charities, helping the gentry preserve their role as central patrons of local society.

Accordingly, I hypothesize that in regions where clan institutions remained resilient, they functioned as substitutes for religious sects by providing a pre-existing infrastructure for elite governance and social control. This established organizational capacity likely crowded out the functional necessity of sectarian organizations. If these mechanisms of substitution and displacement were operative, the positive association between gentry size and sectarian activity should be significantly attenuated in regions with strong clans.

Following established literature, I measure clan strength using the number of compiled genealogies per 100,000 people prior to 1911 (Cao et al., 2020; Dincecco and Wang, 2021). Genealogies

(jiapu) were formal records maintained by lineages to document family history, affirm ancestral worship, and enforce moral norms. Because their compilation required significant organizational capacity and economic resources, a high density of genealogies serves as a reliable proxy for strong clan organizations.

I draw data on genealogies from the Shanghai Library Genealogy Catalog (Shanghai Jiapu Zongmu), the most comprehensive nationwide collection of Chinese genealogical records. Approximately 90% of these records can be accurately geocoded to the county level. I aggregate these counts by county and merge them with the sectarian dataset. To address the right-skewness of the distribution, I construct a binary indicator classifying counties as having a strong clan presence if their genealogy density exceeds the national median.

To examine the heterogeneous effects of gentry size on sectarian activities, I run the specifications in Table 2, Column 6, where prefecture-level fixed effects and distance to the sectarian center are controlled, on two subsamples: clan-weak regions, defined as places where clan strength is below the median, and clan-strong regions, where clan strength is above the median.

Table 4: The Impact of Gentry Density on Sectarianism by Lineage Strength

Dependent Variable	Sect per capita	Sect per capita
	Weak Clan	Strong Clan
Jinshi per capita	58.221*** (19.598)	32.885 (32.010)
Log Distance	455.150 (1276.673)	-1212.957 (952.397)
Observations	446	467
R ²	0.552	0.414
Prefecture FE	X	X

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the prefecture level.

The results in Table 4 support the logic of institutional substitution. The correlation between gentry density and sectarian activities is much stronger in clan-weak regions, as the coefficient

is approximately 80% higher than in clan-strong places and highly statistically significant. In contrast, in regions with a strong clan presence, the relationship is substantially attenuated and lacks statistical significance. This divergence indicates that where robust kinship networks were already established, the gentry absorbed the shock caused by the revolution by investing heavily in clan structures. Conversely, in regions lacking cohesive clan organizations, the gentry were compelled to capture sectarian networks to achieve the same objectives.

Conclusion

This paper addresses a central challenge faced by incumbent elites after a major political rupture such as regime change: how can they preserve their power, influence, and prestige once their privileged access to the state is disrupted? Departing from state-centered accounts that emphasize how elites maintain power through formal political institutions, I argue that threatened elites can build a power base outside the state by investing in social institutions, especially religious organizations. These organizations provide alternative sources of influence and prestige for elites who have lost direct political power, while also allowing them to preserve their dominance in grassroots society, particularly where the state remains weak.

Empirically, the paper applies this framework to the rise of religious sects in Republican China. Challenging the conventional view that religious sects were primarily weapons of the weak, I show that they were more active in regions with larger populations of traditional gentry elites whose status was threatened by the revolution. This pattern suggests that the gentry strategically used religious sects as organizational vehicles through which to preserve influence after the Republican Revolution. I further find that this relationship was stronger in regions with weaker clan institutions, consistent with a logic of institutional substitution: elites were more likely to adopt this strategy where existing social organizations could not provide sufficient alternative channels for preserving local dominance.

Although the empirical focus of this paper is China, the theoretical logic extends well beyond this case. After the French Revolution, for example, the nobility increased its investment in the

Catholic Church. By embedding noble networks and prestige within the Church and Church-affiliated institutions, this strategy enabled the nobility to sustain influence in local society long after the revolution (Gibson, 1989). Similarly, in post-revolutionary Mexico, landed elites preserved local influence by investing in Catholic lay organizations and church-centered social networks, which generated social capital, reinforced ties to clergy, and helped them resist agrarian reform and secular state-building (Fallaw, 2013).

The Chinese case simultaneously reveals the inherent limits of this survival strategy. While religious sects enabled the gentry to navigate the transition of the Republican revolution, this approach proved inadequate against the radical social revolution initiated by the Chinese Communist Party. Through land reform (Siu, 1989), the Campaign to Suppress Counterrevolutionaries (Hung, 2010), and subsequent waves of political mobilization, the CCP dismantled the institutional foundations of traditional elite power, specifically religious sects and clans. Consequently, although traditional elites may preserve their influence after a moderate political revolution by retreating into social institutions, such a strategy is ineffective during a radical social revolution. In the latter scenario, the new regime does not merely strip the old elites of formal political authority but systematically destroys the social infrastructure that sustains their informal power.

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Appendix A Summary Statistics

Table A.1: Summary Statistics of Key Variables

	Mean	Median	Min	Max	SD	N
Members per capita	3792.56	2065.56	6.06	39695.20	4689.59	1078
Leaders per capita	211.02	114.34	0.68	4568.73	317.13	690
Jinshi per capita	3.96	1.15	0.00	164.05	9.41	1078
Log Distance to Historical Sectarian Centers	6.13	6.20	0.00	8.02	0.89	1080
Geneology per capita	26.43	0.00	0.00	1375.99	102.57	1086

Appendix B Gazetteer Example

Figure A.1: Gazetteer Example from Yishui County, Shandong

沂水县

解放前，沂水县有圣贤道、大佛道、一贯道、龙华道、金丹道、西乾道、大成道、青居道、中央道、软弱无畏道、九宫道、后天收元道、乾坤道、黄母道、东镇道、妈妈会、无坛善、茹素斋团等反动会道门组织 18 种之多，其中历史最长、组织最大、活动最广、危害最烈者主要有圣贤道、大佛道、一贯道和茹素斋团。

圣贤道 始于 1906 年（光绪 32 年）。开初由张文标、卜照民等人从费县、东平引入沂水。该道几乎分布全县，主要活动在夏蔚、王庄、崔家峪、院东头、马站、四十里堡一带。据 1951 年统计，该道道徒 35000 余人。

大佛道 以刘成页、刘敬为首的大佛道，活动于沂城、许家湖、崔家峪、马站一带。1940 年道首刘成页先后窜到天津、济南等地，与日本侵略军勾结，阴谋发动暴乱。1944 年冬，以邱锡三、李洪吉为首的大佛道徒，在马站区石砬村发动暴乱，杀害村干部、民兵和鲁

中军区十二团生产股战士 16 人，杀伤民兵和战士 4 人，夺去步枪 20 支。该道有道徒 4200 余人。

一贯道 又名中华道德慈善会，初由路中一承办道务。路于 1925 年死后，由张光壁继承，张投靠日本侵略军发展道徒。此间，该道传入沂水，主要活动在沂城、柴山、崔家峪、武家洼一带，有道徒 1600 余人。

茹素斋 于 1892 年（清光绪 18 年）传入，道首是益都县夏家新庄的夏永祥。夏永祥死后，其子夏光斗（字星元）继承其衣钵，大力发展道徒。1911 年（宣统 3 年）由沂水县沭河区（今圈里乡一带）良门庆的刘光荣、獐子峪村胡凤良，将该道引入沂水，活动于杨庄、马站、官庄、圈里一带。1939 年，茹素斋团道首王九锡，依靠国民党山东省主席沈鸿烈和国民党苏鲁战区总司令于学忠当上了莒县、沂水、安丘边区少将自卫团长和苏鲁战区总司令部少将参议。从此，茹素斋团的道徒们也狐假虎威，为所欲为。

1949 年 6 月 1 日，按照山东省人民政府取缔会道门的指示，沂中、沂北、沂东、莒沂边等县公安局发动群众，检举揭发了反动会道门的罪恶，对办道者进行了登记。1951 年 5 月 10 日，遵照省人民政府严厉取缔会道门的指示，沂水、莒沂^① 两县人民统一行动，逮捕了 107 名反动会道门道首。县公安局在宣传政策，发动群众的基础上，进一步进行登记工作，先后登记的有圣贤道 951 人，中央道 9 人，龙华道 1 人，大佛道 1 人，东镇道 1 人。通过这次登记，自动退道的一般道徒有 13610 余人。

Translation: The Shengxian Way was established in 1906, the thirty-second year of the Guangxu Emperor's reign. It was initially introduced to Yishui from Fei County and Dongping by individuals such as Zhang Wenbiao and Bu Zhaomin. This sect was distributed across almost the entire county, with its primary activities centered in the areas of Xiawei, Wangzhuang, Cuijiayu, Yuandongtou, Mazhan, and Sishilibao. According to statistics from 1951, the sect maintained a membership of over 35,000 adherents.

The Great Buddha Way, led by Liu Chengye and Liu Jing, operated in Yicheng, Xujiahu, Cuijiayu, and Mazhan. In 1940, the sect leader Liu Chengye traveled to cities such as Tianjin and Jinan to collude with the Japanese invading army in a conspiracy to launch uprisings. In the winter of 1944, adherents of the Great Buddha Way led by Qiu Xisan and Li Hongji initiated a riot in Shila Village within the Mazhan district. During this conflict, they killed sixteen individuals, including village cadres, militiamen, and soldiers from the production department of the 12th Regiment of the Central Shandong Military Region. They also wounded four militiamen and soldiers and seized twenty rifles. The sect recorded a total of over 4,200 adherents.

Yiguandao, also known as the Chinese Moral Benevolent Society, was initially managed by Lu Zhongyi. After Lu's death in 1925, Zhang Guangbi succeeded him and relied on the Japanese invading army to expand the sect's membership. During this period, the organization spread to Yishui, where it was primarily active in Yicheng, Chaishan, Cuijiayu, and Wujiawa, reaching a membership of over 1,600 adherents.

Rusuzhai was introduced to the region in 1892, the eighteenth year of the Guangxu Emperor's reign. Its leader was Xia Yongxiang from Xiajiaxinzhuang in Yidu County. Upon his death, his son Xia Guangdou, who used the courtesy name Xingyuan, inherited the leadership and vigorously expanded the group's membership. In 1911, the third year of the Xuantong Emperor's reign, Liu Guangrong from Liangmenqing and Hu Fengliang from Zhangziyu Village in the Wuhe District of Yishui introduced the sect to the county. It operated in Yangzhuang, Mazhan, Guanzhuang, and Quanli. In 1939, Wang Jiuxi, a leader of the Rusuzhai group, utilized his connections with the Nationalist Governor of Shandong, Shen Honglie, and the Commander-in-Chief of the Jiangsu-Shandong War Zone, Yu Xuezhong, to secure appointments as a Major General and commander of the self-defense regiment in the border region of Ju County, Yishui, and Anqiu, as well as a Major General Counselor at the Jiangsu-Shandong War Zone Headquarters. Following this, the adherents of the Rusuzhai group exploited their political influence to act with total impunity.

On June 1, 1949, in accordance with directives from the Shandong Provincial People's Government to suppress sects and secret societies, the Public Security Bureaus of Yizhong, Yibei, Yidong, and Juyi counties mobilized the masses to report the crimes of these reactionary organizations and conducted registrations of those managing the sects. On May 10, 1951, following further instructions for strict suppression, the people of Yishui and Juyi counties conducted unified operations and arrested 107 leaders of reactionary sects. Building on the foundation of policy propaganda and mass mobilization, the County Public Security Bureau proceeded with further registration. The individuals subsequently registered included 951 from the Shengxian Way, 9 from the Central Way, 1 from the Longhua Way, 1 from the Great Buddha Way, and 1 from the Dongzhen Way. Through this registration process, more than 13,610 ordinary adherents officially registered their automatic withdrawal from these organizations.

Appendix C Robustness Checks

Appendix C.1 Excluding Ethnic Minority Regions

Table A.2: Gentry Density and Sectarian Members

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
DV:	Sectarian Adherent Density					
Jinshi per capita	78.779*** (21.181)	56.237*** (18.458)	44.292** (22.310)	68.722*** (22.116)	59.013*** (18.456)	44.500* (22.626)
Dist. to Sect Center (km)				-1.622*** (0.467)	1.317 (1.624)	-4.578 (4.871)
Observations	1036	1036	976	1032	1032	972
R^2	0.026	0.215	0.410	0.050	0.220	0.422
Province FE		X			X	
Prefecture FE			X			X

Note: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the prefecture level. The sample excludes Tibet, Inner Mongolia, and Xinjiang, as these regions did not participate in the imperial examination system.

Table A.3: Gentry Density and Sectarian Leaders

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
DV:	Sectarian Leader Density					
Jinshi per capita	4.368*** (1.379)	4.397*** (1.498)	3.637** (1.524)	4.124*** (1.350)	4.463*** (1.499)	3.584** (1.531)
Dist. to Sect Center (Log)				-17.591 (11.452)	6.276 (42.113)	-77.910 (79.990)
Observations	694	693	616	691	690	611
R^2	0.022	0.103	0.432	0.024	0.104	0.433
Province FE		X			X	
Prefecture FE			X			X

Note: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the prefecture level. The sample excludes Tibet, Inner Mongolia, and Xinjiang, as these regions did not participate in the imperial examination system.

Appendix C.2 Log Transformation of DVs

Table A.4: Gentry Density and Redemptive Society Expansion

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
DV:	log(1 + Sectarian Members)					
Jinshi per capita	0.017*** (0.004)	0.013*** (0.004)	0.006* (0.003)	0.012*** (0.004)	0.012*** (0.004)	0.006* (0.003)
Dist. to Sect Center (km)				-0.001*** (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.001 (0.001)
Observations	1078	1078	1013	1073	1073	1008
R^2	0.016	0.277	0.511	0.079	0.279	0.515
Province FE		X			X	
Prefecture FE			X			X

Note: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the prefecture level. The dependent variable is the natural logarithm of the number of sectarian members plus one, i.e., $\log(1 + \text{members})$.

Table A.5: Gentry Density and Sectarian Leadership Concentration

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
DV:	log(1 + Sectarian Leaders)					
Jinshi per capita	0.016*** (0.004)	0.017*** (0.003)	0.012*** (0.003)	0.015*** (0.004)	0.017*** (0.003)	0.012*** (0.003)
Dist. to Sect Center (km)				-0.000** (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	-0.001 (0.001)
Observations	690	689	612	687	686	607
R^2	0.022	0.251	0.478	0.035	0.252	0.478
Province FE		X			X	
Prefecture FE			X			X

Note: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the prefecture level. The dependent variable is the natural logarithm of the number of sectarian leaders plus one, i.e., $\log(1 + \text{leaders})$.